Tree

沈威宇

November 1, 2026

1 Tree

I Tree

i Tree

A tree is an abstract data type of a set of nodes. A relationship between two nodes i, j is defined with

- i is called a child of j and
- j is called a parent of i; and
- a node can have at most one parent.

If not empty, a tree is recursively defined as a distinguished node r called root and zero or more nonempty trees called subtrees, where the root of each substree is a child of r.

- Nodes sharing the same parent are called siblings. Children of a node are defined with a left to right order.
- A node with no children is called a leaf, external node, or exterior node.
- A node that is not a leaf is called an internal node or interior node.
- The number of edges from the root to a node is called the depth of the node, while the root has depth 0.
- The maximum depth of the nodes is called the height or depth of the tree.
- The ancestors of a node is recursively defined as itself for root and itself and the ancestors of its parent for non-root nodes.
- The descendants of a node is recursively defined as itself for leaves and itself and the descendants of its children for internal nodes.
- Nodes of the same depth are called a level. Levels are ordered by depth. The left-to-right order of nodes in a level is defined recursively to, if they are siblings, follow that of siblings; otherwise follow that of their parents.
- A tree consisting of all descendants of a node is called a subtree. The left-to-right order of subtrees whose roots are of the same depth are defined as that of their roots. A subtree whose root is a child of a node is called a subtree of the node.

ii Tree representation

A representation of tree where each pair of parent and child is connected with a edge.

iii Left child, right sibling representation

A representation of tree where each internal node and its leftmost child is connected with a edge, and each sibling that is not the leftmost one is called to the sibling at its left.

II n-ary tree

i n-ary tree

A tree in which no node can have more than n children is called an n-ary tree.

ii Full, proper, or plane

An n-ary tree where each internal node has exactly n children is called full, proper, or plane.

iii Filled

A level of depth $k \in \mathbb{N}$ of an n-ary tree is called filled iff each node in the level of depth $k - 1$ has exactly n children. The level of depth 0 is called filled iff the tree is nonempty.

iv Complete

An n-ary tree where every level, except possibly the last, is filled and whose nodes in the last level are as far left as possible, is called complete.

A complete n-ary tree is indexed from top to bottom and then from left to right, with the root as node 1.

v Perfect

A complete n-ary tree where all leaves are of the same depth is called perfect.

A perfect n-ary tree with height k has $\sum_{j=0}^{k} n^j$ nodes.

III Binary tree

i Binary tree

In a binary tree, the two possible children of a node are called left child and right child. A child is either left or right but not both even if it has no sibling.

ii Complete binary tree

For a complete binary tree with n nodes:

- Parent of node i is node $\left\lfloor \frac{i}{2} \right\rfloor$ for all integers $i > 1$.
- The left child of node i is $2i + 1$ for all integers $i \leq \frac{n-1}{2}$.
- The right child of node i is $2i$ for all integers $i \leq \frac{n}{2}$.

iii Perfect binary tree

A perfect binary tree with height k has $2^{k+1} - 1$ nodes.

iv Balanced tree

A type of binary tree with height $O(\log n)$ where n is the number of nodes is called balanced.

IV Tree traversal

They are defined recursively. Suppose the root is r.

i Preorder traversal

First visit r, and then visit the subtrees of r from left to right.

ii Postorder traversal

Visit the subtrees of r from left to right, and finally visit r.

iii Inorder traversal (binary tree)

First visit the left subtree of r, and then visit r, and then visit the right subtree of r.

V Binary search tree (BST)

i Binary search tree (BST)

A binary search tree stores keys in the nodes of a binary tree so that searching, insertion and deletion can be done efficiently. For every node x, all the keys in its left subtree are smaller than x and all keys in its right subtree are larger than x.

ii Searching

Suppose we are searching for x and the root is r.

- If $x = r$, then we are done.
- If $x < r$, then we search in the left subtree.
- If $x > r$, then we search in the right subtree.

The time complexity is O(height of tree).

iii Finding minimum and maximum

To find the node containing the smallest key, start at root and go to the left child as long as there is one, and the leaf we stop at is the smallest key. Similarly for find the largest key.

The time complexity is O(height of tree).

iv Insertion

Suppose we want to insert x. First search for it, if we found it, do noting (or update something); otherwise, if we stop at y,

- if $x > y$, insert x as the right child of y if $x > y$, and
- if $x < y$, insert x as the left child of y.

The time complexity is O(height of tree).

v Deletion

Suppose we want to delete x. First search for it, if we don't found it, do noting (or update something); otherwise,

- if it is a leaf, delete it,
- if it has one child y, adjust y as a child of the parent of x of the same position as x and delete x, and
- if it has two children, replace it with the minimum element y in the right subtree of x and delete the node y, which is a leaf.

The time complexity is O(height of tree).

vi Uniqueness given preorder traversal

A BST with distinct values is uniquely determined by its preorder traversal.

Proof. A BST with one node is obviously unique. The first element must be root, the second element to the last element smaller than root must be the left subtree, and the rest must be the right subtree. Recursively partition into the subtrees. We uniquely obtained the BST. □

vii Uniqueness given postorder traversal

A BST with distinct values is uniquely determined by its postorder traversal.

Proof. A BST with one node is obviously unique. The last element must be root, the first element to the last element smaller than root must be the left subtree, and the rest must be the right subtree. Recursively partition into the subtrees. We uniquely obtained the BST. □

viii Inorder traversal is in ascending order

Inorder traversal of a BST always produces values in ascending order.

VI AVL tree (Adelson-Velsky and Landis tree)

i AVL tree (Adelson-Velsky and Landis tree)

An AVL tree is a self-balancing binary search tree (BST). The height for AVL trees is defined differing from that of a tree:

- The height of a leaf is defined as 1.
- The height of an internal node is defined as the maximum height of its children plus 1.
- The height of an AVL tree is defined as the height of its root, which is thus one more than the earlier definition for general tree.

An AVL tree needs to comply with the property that for every node with two children in the tree, the height of its left and right subtrees differ by at most 1.

ii Minimum and maximum numbers of nodes

Let the minimum number of nodes in an AVL tree of height h be N_h. Since the minimum numbers of subtrees height of the root of an AVL tree of height h are $h-1$ and $h-2$, we have:

$$N_0 = 0$$

$$N_1 = 1$$

$$N_h = N_{h-1} + N_{h-2} + 1, \quad h-2 \in \mathbb{N}_0$$

Let $\varphi = \dfrac{1+\sqrt{5}}{2}$ denote the golden ratio.

$$N_h = \frac{1}{\varphi+2}\left(\varphi^{h+3} + \left(-\frac{1}{\varphi}\right)^{h+1}\right) - 1$$

Proof. Note that

$$\frac{1-\sqrt{5}}{2} = 1-\varphi = -\frac{1}{\varphi}$$

$$\frac{3+\sqrt{5}}{2} = \varphi^2 = \varphi + 1$$

$$\frac{3-\sqrt{5}}{2} = \frac{1}{\varphi^2} = -\frac{1}{\varphi} + 1$$

Use characteristic equation:

$$x^2 - x - 1 = 0$$

$$x = \frac{1 \pm \sqrt{5}}{2} = \varphi, -\frac{1}{\varphi}$$

$$N_h = a\varphi^h + b\left(-\frac{1}{\varphi}\right)^h + c$$

$$N_0 = a + b + c = 0$$

$$N_1 = a\varphi - \frac{b}{\varphi} + c = 1$$

$$N_2 = a\varphi^2 + \frac{b}{\varphi^2} + c = 0 + 1 + 1 = 2$$

$$a(\varphi - 1) - b\left(\frac{1}{\varphi} + 1\right) = 1$$

$$\frac{a}{\varphi} - b\varphi = 1$$

$$a - b(\varphi + 1) = \varphi$$

$$a\left(\varphi^2 - 1\right) + b\left(\frac{1}{\varphi^2} - 1\right) = 2$$

$$a\varphi - \frac{b}{\varphi} = 2$$

$$b(\varphi + 1)\varphi + \varphi^2 - \frac{b}{\varphi} = 2$$

$$b(\varphi + 2) + \varphi = 1$$

$$b = \frac{1 - \varphi}{\varphi + 2} = -\frac{1}{\varphi}\frac{1}{\varphi + 2}$$

$$a = -\frac{\varphi}{\varphi + 2} + \varphi = \frac{\varphi^2 + \varphi}{\varphi + 2} = \frac{\varphi^3}{\varphi + 2}$$

$$c = \frac{-\varpi^2 - \varphi - 1 + \varphi}{\varphi + 2} = -1$$

$$N_h = \frac{1}{\varphi + 2}\left(\varphi^{h+3} + \left(-\frac{1}{\varphi}\right)^{h+1}\right) - 1$$

□

So

$$N_h = \Theta(\varphi^h)$$

$$h = \log_\varphi N_h + O(1) \approx 1.44 \log_2 N_h + O(1)$$

Let the maximum number of nodes in an AVL tree of height h be M_h. Since the maximum numbers of subtrees height of the root of an AVL tree of height h are $h-1$, we have:

$$M_0 = 0$$

$$M_h = 2M_{h-1} + 1, \quad h \in \mathbb{N}$$

$$M_h = 2^h - 1, \quad h \in \mathbb{N}_0$$

So

$$M_h \in \Theta(\log_2 M_h)$$

$$h = \log_2 M_h + O(1)$$

Let the number of nodes be n.

$$N_h \leq n \leq M_h$$

$$\log_2 n + O(1) \leq h \leq \log_\varphi n + O(1) \approx 1.44 \log_2 N_h + O(1)$$

Thus

$$h \in \Theta(\log n)$$

iii Searching and finding minimum/maximum

Searching and finding minimum/maximum in AVL tree is the same as in BST.

The time complexity is $O(\text{height of tree}) = O(\log \text{number of nodes})$.

iv Rotation

When insertion/deletion, the AVL tree property may be violated, called unbalanced. Since an insertion/deletion involves adding/deleting a single node, this can only increase/decrease the height of some subtree by 1. Thus, if the AVL tree property is violated at a node x, it means that the heights of left and right subtrees of it differ by exactly 2. We need to transform the tree to restore the AVL tree property, called rebalancing, using a single or double rotation.

- LL case: Let the left child of x be y. The LL case is where the left subtree of y has height $h+1$, while the right subtree of y and the right subtree of x have height h. We perform a right single rotation by moving y to the position of x, moving x as the right child of y, and moving the original right subtree of y as the left subtree of x.
- RR case: Let the right child of x be y. The RR case is where the right tree of y has height $h+1$, while the left subtree of y and the left subtree of x have height h. We perform a left single rotation by moving y to the position of x, moving x as the left child of y, and moving the original left subtree of y as the right subtree of x.

- LR case: Let the left child of x be y, and the right child of y be z. The LR case is where the right subtree of y has height $h+1$, while the left subtree of y and the right subtree of x have height h. We perform a left-then-right double rotation by doing a left single rotation at y (i.e., moving z to the position of y, moving y as the left child of z, and moving the original left subtree of z as the right subtree of y) and then a right single rotation at x (i.e., moving y to the position of x, moving x as the right child of y, and moving the original right subtree of y as the left subtree of x).
- RL case: Let the right child of x be y, and the left child of y be z. The RL case is where the left subtree of y has height $h+1$, while the right subtree of y and the left subtree of x have height h. We perform a right-then-left double rotation by doing a right single rotation at y (i.e., moving z to the position of y, moving y as the right child of z, and moving the original right subtree of z as the left subtree of y) and then a left single rotation at x (i.e., moving y to the position of x, moving x as the left child of y, and moving the original left subtree of y as the right subtree of x).

v Insertion

Insertion in AVL tree involves first doing insertion the same as in BST, and then tracing the path from the new leaf to the root: For each node x encountered, check if heights of its left and right subtrees differ by at most 1,

- if yes, proceed to the parent of x;
- if not, we say the AVL tree property is violated at x and perform rotations to restore it, and then break the loop since no second violation may exist for insertion.

The time complexity is $O(\text{height of tree}) = O(\log \text{number of nodes})$.

vi Deletion

Deletion in AVL tree involves first doing deletion the same as in BST, and then tracing the path from the parent of the deleted node to the root: For each node x encountered, check if heights of its left and right subtrees differ by at most 1,

- if yes, proceed to the parent of x;
- if not, we say the AVL tree property is violated at x and perform rotations to restore it, and then proceed to the parent of x since violation may propagate upwards for deletion.

The time complexity is $O(\text{height of tree}) = O(\log \text{number of nodes})$.